

blueprint, one that allows the partner who makes more to pay more and the one who makes less to make a contribution commensurate to his or her income.

This works for same-sex couples as well. Whoever initiates the date pays. After that, one offers to pay, the other to contribute. Once more, financial information is uncovered and shared. I suggest you employ rational ratios. Whoever makes more pays more. Period. You work out the specifics. Simply put, as the relationship progresses, each party should start to take turns paying for things, splitting expenses roughly equitable to what each earns, especially on things enjoyed as a couple, such as trips and meals. Using this method, you will naturally begin to know what each earns, how each spends, and what each person in the relationship expects in terms of money and spending.

Money Mistake: You're in Love, So You're Shacking Up

THE FIX: KNOW YOUR COMMON-LAW RIGHTS

The reasons for moving in together should be about money, too, not just love. After all, studies show that couples who live together before they get married aren't really inoculated against divorce. So lose the romantic idea that living together is practice for getting married, or that you'll make a better husband or wife because of it. If you're shacking up with your partner, it's important that you get a cohabitation agreement to avoid common financial dramas. Never assume that living together is "marriage lite."

A cohabitation agreement is like a *pre*-prenup, and can cost about \$1,000 to \$4,000. If things go south and you head to court, a cohabitation agreement can protect any assets that you bring to the arrangement and keep you from absorbing any of your partner's poor financial decisions. It can also lay out exactly who pays for what while you're living together, how money is managed, what shifts financially in the event of children, and more important, who inherits your money when you die. I say "more important" because child support falls under a different category, in that regardless of whether you're